Depth-repair supplement — Vetti, Jogini, Devadasi and anti-caste reform in Telangana

Paper II / Unit II / Topic 4 — Socio-Cultural Awakening in Telangana. Prepared 25 October 2026. **Scope:** an original substantive appendix to an older shallow draft; the existing main chapter and original PDF remain unchanged. The supplement is not a substitute for a complete chapter rewrite and is not academically approved. It contains no purported official previous-year questions.

1. Why these social practices belong in a history of reform

A socio-cultural awakening is not simply the establishment of libraries or the appearance of new newspapers. It also involves struggles over who may read, own land, control labour, enter institutions, marry freely and claim dignity. Hyderabad State contained different religious, linguistic and caste communities; patterns of exclusion varied by region and community. The Telangana government's 2026 SEEEPC volume identifies vetti, jeetham and jogini servitude as practices associated with entrenched caste-feudal relations, with particular burdens on Dalit communities [R1]. That official summary is a starting point, not evidence that every village followed an identical system.

Reform should be studied through three linked questions: **(a)** What made the practice possible? **(b)** Who organised against it, through what institutions and cultural languages? **(c)** What changed legally, socially and materially? The same individual could face restrictions in labour, education, worship and public participation. Therefore reform cannot be reduced to a single law or leader. In mains answers, separate the social structure, the experience of those affected, the reform movement and the limits of reform. Avoid presenting victims only as passive recipients of benevolence: oppressed communities organised, petitioned, taught, resisted and built institutions.

2. Vetti — forced unpaid labour and the political economy of caste

Definition and social setting. Vetti refers to compelled labour rendered without fair payment or without a genuinely free choice to refuse. In Telangana's historical caste-feudal order, such obligations could be imposed through village power relations and land dependence. It should not be conflated automatically with every form of agricultural wage labour: the defining issue is coercion and the denial of meaningful consent. The 2026 Telangana SEEEPC survey volume specifically names vetti as forced unpaid labour and situates it among structural forms of caste-feudal exploitation [R1]. A textbook account should identify both the material extraction of labour and the degradation of status involved.

How the system operated. Control over land, credit, access to village resources and local authority could make refusal costly. Families dependent on landlords or village intermediaries might be expected to supply work for domestic service, agricultural operations, transport or other demands. The form and severity differed across localities. Labour obligations also reproduced social hierarchy: a community assigned compulsory tasks had less time for independent cultivation, schooling or paid work. This created a feedback loop in which poverty increased dependence, and dependence made coercion harder to escape. A single 'unpaid hours' estimate would not capture the loss of bargaining power or humiliation.

Resistance and reform. Anti-caste movements, peasant organisations and expanding educational networks challenged the legitimacy of hereditary servitude. Campaigns for self-respect made the issue political: the claim was not merely that a worker deserved a higher wage, but that no person should be bound by caste to another's service. The later constitutional and statutory framework against forced labour reflects a wider Indian rights transformation; Article 23 prohibits traffic in human beings, begar and similar forms of forced labour, while the Bonded Labour System (Abolition) Act, 1976 addresses bonded labour. These later laws should not be projected backward as if they were already operative under the Nizam.

Analytical distinction. Vetti and jeetham can overlap but are not identical labels. Jeetham is often discussed in relation to debt-linked or bonded service, whereas vetti highlights unpaid compelled

labour. Precise local usage requires source-specific evidence. The historian must distinguish debt, caste duty, landlord power and state demands instead of treating them as one undifferentiated category.

Mains conclusion. Vetti illustrates how economic exploitation and social subordination reinforced each other. Reform required both rights-based opposition to coercion and changes in access to land, education and collective organisation. The continuing exam lesson is to analyse power relations and lived experience, not merely memorise a definition.

3. Jogini — dedication, gendered vulnerability and the demand for dignity

Meaning and context. The jogini practice in parts of the Deccan involved the dedication of girls or women to a deity or religious institution, in settings where the social consequences could include restricted marital autonomy, stigma and sexual exploitation. The precise customs varied, and not every person described by a local religious label experienced identical circumstances. Nevertheless, the historical issue for social reform is whether religious language and caste hierarchy were used to normalise the denial of a woman's choice. Telangana's 2026 SEEEPC report explicitly identifies jogini servitude among the exploitative practices borne disproportionately by Dalit communities [R1].

Root causes and mechanisms. Poverty, unequal control over family resources, caste discrimination, lack of schooling, patriarchal expectations and the power of local patrons could make dedication difficult to resist. An explanation that blames only 'superstition' is incomplete: it ignores the economic and political incentives of people who benefited from women's restricted autonomy. The practice could affect a woman's ability to form a household on her own terms, pursue education, control earnings or secure social recognition. A historian must avoid treating religious practice itself as a sufficient explanation for exploitation; the coercive social arrangement is the object of critique.

Organised opposition. The Telangana SCERT social-studies textbook records that Bhagyareddy Varma and other Dalit reformers campaigned against the dedication of girls as devadasis or joginis, and linked this struggle to education and anti-untouchability work [R2]. This matters because reform was not confined to elite legislative debate. Activists used community meetings, schools, popular cultural forms and public arguments to challenge caste stigma and defend dignity. Their initiatives formed part of a wider movement for access to education and equal social standing.

Law and implementation. Modern legal prohibitions on dedication practices must be distinguished from historical campaigns that preceded them. The Andhra Pradesh Devadasis (Prohibition of Dedication) Act, 1988 is relevant to the legal history of the region, but a claim about its current Telangana application should be checked against authoritative state legal records and amendments before exam use. Law alone cannot resolve social exclusion if survivors lack schooling, income, healthcare, safe housing or access to justice. An administrative answer should include rehabilitation and community participation, not simply prosecution.

Mains conclusion. The jogini issue joins caste, gender, economic vulnerability and the politics of religious authority. Reform is best evaluated by women's actual freedom, education, safety and livelihood options rather than by the formal disappearance of a label.

4. Devadasi — distinguishing historical institutions from coercive dedication

Terminology and historical caution. Devadasi is a broad historical term associated with women dedicated to temple service in different regions and periods. It has included complex relationships to music, dance, patronage, ritual and social status. A responsible account does not claim that every devadasi in every period was a victim of the same practice, nor that all cultural performance traditions are reducible to sexual exploitation. However, some forms of dedication became entangled with caste hierarchy, economic dependence and denial of choice. In Telangana reform history, the relevant examination issue is the struggle against **coercive dedication and exploitation**, especially where girls lacked meaningful consent.

Comparison with jogini. The terms are related in reform literature but should not be used as perfect synonyms. 'Jogini' has a more specific regional usage in parts of Telangana and the Deccan; 'devadasi' is used more widely across South Asian temple-service histories. The SCERT Telangana textbook discusses campaigns against dedicating girls as devadasis or joginis [R2], which supports studying their overlap in social reform without erasing differences of place, ritual, class and historical period. In an exam answer, say 'related but context-dependent institutions' rather than inventing a universal definition.

Social and economic dimensions. The historical vulnerability of some dedicated women arose from restrictions on education, property, mobility, marriage and access to alternative livelihoods. These conditions could be reinforced by powerful patrons and social stigma. A moralising account that portrays women as responsible for their exploitation reproduces the injustice it claims to criticise. A better analysis asks who controlled the decision to dedicate, who received the benefits, whether exit was possible and what material resources survivors possessed.

Reform and cultural politics. Anti-caste organisers, women's advocates and educators questioned the legitimacy of hereditary obligations imposed on girls. At the same time, reform movements sometimes debated how to protect women without dismissing all forms of performance culture. The historian should distinguish preservation of artistic traditions from preservation of coercive social relations. Cultural history and human-rights analysis are complementary, not mutually exclusive.

Mains conclusion. Devadasi history requires nuance: examine diversity of institutions, then focus precisely on coercion, discrimination and restricted agency where evidence supports those claims. This distinction improves both factual accuracy and the ethical quality of an answer.

5. Bhagyareddy Varma, Adi-Hindu assertion and educational reform

Background. Telangana's SCERT social-studies text identifies Bhagyareddy Varma (1888–1939) as an important Dalit reformer and records his role in raising awareness, opposing untouchability and promoting education [R2]. It associates his work with the Jagan Mitra Mandali established in 1906. The government's 2026 SEEEPC volume also links Varma to the Adi Hindu Social Service League in 1922 and emphasises his use of public communication and cultural forms [R1]. These dates should be presented with the named source because organisations may appear under variant names in different historical accounts.

Ideas and methods. The language of 'Adi Hindu' asserted dignity and challenged caste ranking by contesting narratives of social inferiority. Reformers established educational initiatives, organised community discussion and used familiar cultural media to reach people excluded from formal institutions. This combination is significant: literacy could widen access to employment and public argument, while collective organisation gave individuals greater capacity to resist local power. The movement should not be described as a single-person achievement; Varma's role belongs within a network of community organisers, teachers and participants.

Relation to women's reform. The SCERT textbook explicitly connects Dalit reform campaigns to opposition against dedication of girls as joginis or devadasis [R2]. Thus anti-untouchability and women's dignity were linked, rather than separate chapters with no connection. The larger analytical lesson is that social hierarchies intersect: caste, gender, poverty and literacy jointly shaped the options available to individuals.

Historical evaluation. Do not treat a reform organisation's founding date as proof that exploitation ended. Measure outcomes through education, participation, changing social norms and the durability of collective institutions. A strong mains answer should identify the movement's ideas, concrete methods and constraints, then conclude with its contribution to Telangana's socio-cultural awakening.

6. Libraries, Telugu public discussion and the wider awakening

Libraries and reading rooms were important because they created spaces for language, debate and organisation outside narrow official channels. Telangana SCERT records the Andhra Jana Sangham's

efforts under Madapati Hanumantha Rao and others to establish libraries, reading rooms, circulate Telugu manuscripts and publish booklets [R3]. Its account describes education and petitions as early objectives before wider social and political demands emerged. This is a sequence of expanding public participation, not a claim that every library was a revolutionary organisation.

Reading movements helped connect students, scholars, peasants, workers and other groups through shared texts and meetings. Yet the social reach of literacy was unequal: caste, gender, wealth and geography could limit who entered those spaces. A critical history therefore asks whether the library movement broadened participation among women and marginalised communities and how reformers addressed barriers. Its significance lies in the emergence of an informed public sphere and the circulation of claims about rights, education and social reform.

Comparison and conclusion. Vetti concerned coerced labour; jogini and some forms of devadasi dedication concerned gendered and caste-linked restrictions; the Adi-Hindu movement asserted social dignity; and libraries expanded the infrastructure of public argument. Together they reveal that Telangana's socio-cultural awakening was simultaneously economic, educational, gendered and political. This appendix expands these concepts, but the original chapter still needs a full independent academic audit and a deeper treatment of other syllabus components.

Primary-source register and editorial caveats

• **[R1]** Government of Telangana, Directorate of Economics and Statistics, Telangana Socio, Economic, Educational, Employment, Political and Caste (SEEEPC) Survey 2024, report volume published in 2026; discussion of caste-feudal practices and Bhagyareddy Varma. https://des.telangana.gov.in/publications/SEEEPC/SEEEPC-IEWG%20Volume-1%2017-04-26.pdf

• **[R2]** SCERT Telangana, Class VIII Social Studies, social and religious reform movements, free distribution 2022–23; Bhagyareddy Varma and campaigns against jogini/devadasi dedication. https://scert.telangana.gov.in/pdf/publication/ebooks2019/8th%20social%2022-23%20part2%202022-23.pdf

• **[R3]** SCERT Telangana, Class VIII Social Studies, social change under the Nizam, 2020–21 edition; Andhra Jana Sangham, libraries and reading rooms. https://scert.telangana.gov.in/pdf/publication/ebooks2019/8%20social%20em%202020-21.pdf

Quality status: Original supplement, primary institutional source register attached. Exact claims should be checked against the cited report editions and specialist scholarship. The existing chapter remains an unapproved draft; this is a **partial depth repair**, not a complete academic sign-off.